

Cassandra Williams

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AOS | Philosophy of Mind, Cognitive Science
AOC | Philosophy of Science, Philosophy of Biology, Philosophy of Artificial Intelligence,
Philosophy of Action, Philosophy of Sexuality

EDUCATION

Ph.D., Philosophy (in progress)

University of Toronto

2023 - Present

Committee: Denis Walsh (Chair), Andrew Lee, Bill Seager, Evan Thompson

Ph.D. student in Philosophy

York University

2022 - 2023

(Transferred to University of Toronto September 2023)

M.A., History and Philosophy of Science and Technology

University of Toronto

2021

B.A., Philosophy and Cognitive Science

University of Toronto

2019

CONFERENCE PRESENTATIONS

Refereed

1. "Would I Still Have Attention if I Was a Worm?" June 8, 2026
Canadian Philosophical Association, Dalhousie University
2. "Would I Still Have Attention if I Was a Worm?" June 6, 2026
Canadian Society for the History and Philosophy of Science, Dalhousie University
Winner of 2026 Richard Hadden Award
3. "How Speculative is Biopsychism Really?" June 20, 2025
Society for Philosophy and Psychology, Cornell University
4. "How Speculative is Biopsychism Really?" June 12, 2025
The Edge of Sentience Workshop, Ruhr University Bochum
5. "Making Sense of Agency" July 24, 2024
International Conference for Artificial Life, IT University of Copenhagen
6. "Making Sense of Agency" June 21, 2024
Dimensions of Radical Embodiment, University of Murcia

7. "Making Sense of Agency" May 6, 2024
On Purpose, Duke University
8. "Making Sense of Agency" Mar 23, 2024
Southern Society for Philosophy and Psychology, Cincinnati, USA
9. "Radicalism Twice Over: Radical Structuralism, Radical Embodiment, and Subjectivity" June 9, 2023
Berlin Workshop on Ecological Psychology, Technical University of Berlin
10. "Feeling It Out: Affectivity as Minimal Rationality" Mar 18, 2023
Emotions, Reasons, and Rational Agency, University of Tennessee

Non-Refereed

11. "Would I still be sentient if I was a worm???" Oct 20, 2025
Ontario Mind Group, Toronto, Canada

Commentaries

12. Comments on Fermin Fulda, "Life and the Dialectics of Matter and Form: Organicism between Dialectical Materialism and Hylomorphism" Oct 12, 2025
Dialectical Biology Today: Legacies of Richard Lewontin, University of Toronto
13. Comments on Tanya Dushatska, "Artificial Intelligence, Phenomenal Consciousness, and Creative Agency" June 20, 2025
Canadian Philosophical Association, George Brown College

Guest Lectures

14. "Investigating the Mind at its Lower Boundaries" April 24, 2026
Cognitive Science and Theory of Communication, University of Messina

TEACHING

Primary Instructor

Philosophy of Human Sexuality 2026
University of Toronto, Department of Philosophy

Freedom, Responsibility, and Human Action 2026
University of Toronto, Department of Philosophy

Tutorial Leader

Persons, Minds and Bodies 2025
University of Toronto, Department of Philosophy

Minds and Machines 2020, 2024, 2025
University of Toronto, Department of Philosophy

Philosophy of Science 2024
University of Toronto, Department of Philosophy

Introduction to Logic York University, Department of Philosophy	2022
The Limits of Machine Intelligence University of Toronto, Institute for the History and Philosophy of Science and Technology	2021
Introduction to Philosophical Problems University of Toronto, Department of Philosophy	2018-9

FELLOWSHIPS, GRANTS, AND AWARDS

Richard Hadden Award Canadian Society for the History and Philosophy of Science	2026
Graduate Student Service Award Department of Philosophy, University of Toronto	2026
Social Sciences and Humanities Research Council (SSHRC) Doctoral Fellowship	2024 – 2028
Faculty of Arts & Science Top (FAST) Doctoral Fellowship University of Toronto	2023 – 2027
Vision: Science to Applications (VISTA) Doctoral Scholarship York University	2022 – 2023

RESEARCH ASSISTANTSHIPS

Philosophy of Visual Perception Research Assistant to Jake Beck, York University	2022 – 2023
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GRADUATE COURSEWORK

(* = audited, † = in progress)

University of Toronto

Philosophy of Medicine (<i>Brian Baigrie</i>) *	Winter 2026
Biological and Artificial Intelligence (<i>Jennifer Nagel</i>) *	Fall 2025
Representational Content (<i>Imogen Dickie</i>) *	Fall 2025
William James's Radical Empiricism (<i>Bill Seager</i>)	Winter 2024
Aristotle's <i>De Anima</i> (<i>Jessica Gelber</i>)	Winter 2024
Moral Obligations under Conditions of Injustice (<i>Sophia Moreau</i>)	Winter 2024
The Structure of Consciousness (<i>Andrew Lee</i>)	Fall 2023
Spinoza and Hume's Naturalisms (<i>Donald Ainslie, Michael Rosenthal</i>)	Fall 2023
Philosophy of Clinical Epidemiology (<i>Brian Feldman, Brian Baigrie</i>)	Fall 2023
Advanced Intro to Philosophy of Science (<i>Mike Miller</i>)	Fall 2023
Consciousness, Qualia and Qualities (<i>Bill Seager</i>)	Winter 2023

Intro to the History and Philosophy of Science (<i>Brian Baigrie</i>)	Fall 2021
Metaphysics of Quantum Mechanics (<i>Mike Miller, Trevor Teitel</i>)	Fall 2021
Theories of Consciousness (<i>Bill Seager</i>)	Fall 2021
Teleology (<i>Denis Walsh, Marleen Rosemond</i>)	Fall 2021
History and Philosophy of the Social Sciences (<i>Mark Solovey</i>)	Winter 2020
Technology, Environment, and History (<i>Rebecca Woods</i>)	Winter 2020

York University

Stimulus, Context, and Control in Perception (<i>Kevin Lande</i>) *	Winter 2023
Perceptual Justification (<i>Jake Beck, Kevin Lande</i>)	Fall 2022
Rationality (<i>Kristin Andrews</i>)	Fall 2022

CUNY Graduate Center

Animal Consciousness and Society (<i>Kristin Andrews</i>) *	Fall 2025
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SERVICE

Refereeing

Journals: *Philosophical Explorations*

Aristotle Contest 2026
 Department of Philosophy
 University of Toronto

Other Service

Climate Committee Member 2025 – 2026
 Graduate Philosophy Students' Union
 University of Toronto

Volunteer 2025
 Dialectical Biology Today: Legacies of Richard Lewontin conference
 University of Toronto

Graduate Student Peer Mentor 2024 – 2026
 Department of Philosophy
 University of Toronto

Volunteer 2024
 Philosophy Graduate Student Conference
 York University

PROFESSIONAL EXPERIENCE

Research Engagement Coordinator Jan 2026 – July 2026
 Schwartz Reisman Institute for Technology and Society
 University of Toronto